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NEW  
**2027**  
FORMAT

CAMBRIDGE IGCSE • FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH • 0500

# Paper 2

## *Directed Writing*

Four complete Section A tasks for the new 2027 exam, covering the 1(a) structured question and 1(b) directed writing, with model answers for a speech, a letter, an article and a report.

- ◆ 4 full Section A tasks (160 marks)
- ◆ New 1(a) evaluation questions
- ◆ 4 annotated model answers
- ◆ Planning frame & form toolkit
- ◆ 6 original source texts
- ◆ 1(b) in all four forms
- ◆ Mark schemes & indicative content
- ◆ Evaluation phrase bank

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For exams in 2027, 2028 and 2029. Independent practice material; not produced or endorsed by Cambridge University Press & Assessment. All texts are original.

# How to use this pack

From June 2027, Section A of Cambridge IGCSE First Language English (0500) Paper 2 gives candidates one or two texts (about 550–650 words in total) and two linked questions. This pack gives you four complete tasks in that format, one for each form candidates may be asked to write.

| Question | What candidates do                                                                                                                       | Marks             |
|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| 1(a)     | Short structured answers: analyse and evaluate the ideas in the text(s), including how the writer tries to influence readers             | 5                 |
| 1(b)     | Directed writing: a speech, letter, article or report of 250–350 words that uses, develops and <b>evaluates</b> the ideas in the text(s) | 35<br>10 R + 25 W |

## The four tasks

|        |                           |           |         |
|--------|---------------------------|-----------|---------|
| Task 1 | Phones in Schools         | Two texts | Speech  |
| Task 2 | Paying for Paradise       | One text  | Letter  |
| Task 3 | Compulsory School Sport   | Two texts | Article |
| Task 4 | The Future of the Library | One text  | Report  |

## The five-step method for 1(b)

|                 |                                                                                                           |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 Decode        | Circle the form, audience, purpose and the position you will take.                                        |
| 2 Map           | List every argument in the text(s). Mark each one: agree, disagree or “yes, but...”.                      |
| 3 Evaluate      | Question the evidence: Is it reliable? Is it biased? What is missing? Do the texts contradict each other? |
| 4 Plan          | Hook, three developed paragraphs drawn from the texts, a clear conclusion or call to action.              |
| 5 Write & check | 250–350 words in the right form and register. Leave time to proofread.                                    |

### Timed practice

Print the insert and question paper. Allow about one hour for Section A.

### Teach the form

Study the model answer and its notes first, then set a different task in the same form.

### Tutoring

Use Task 1 to diagnose, then work on the weakest strand: evaluation, form or accuracy.

# Form toolkit & evaluation phrase bank

| Form           | Must include                                                                                                                                   | Register                                          |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Speech</b>  | Greeting to the audience; a hook; signposting ("First... Finally..."); direct address and inclusive "we"; a memorable close and thanks         | Engaging, rhetorical, suited to listeners         |
| <b>Letter</b>  | "Dear..."; purpose stated in the first paragraph; one main point per paragraph; polite request or call to action; "Yours sincerely/faithfully" | Formal to officials; warmer to people you know    |
| <b>Article</b> | Headline (and optional subheading); an opening that grabs attention; lively paragraphs; a strong final line                                    | Informative and lively; suited to the publication |
| <b>Report</b>  | Title; "To/From" or purpose line; clear subheadings; balanced findings; numbered recommendations; conclusion                                   | Objective, clear and formal; no emotive language  |

## From repeating to evaluating

|                   |                                                                                                       |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Repeating</b>  | "The text says visitor numbers have fallen by forty per cent."                                        |
| <b>Using</b>      | "Visitor numbers have fallen sharply, which worries the council."                                     |
| <b>Developing</b> | "If fewer people visit, the library may struggle to justify its costs."                               |
| <b>Evaluating</b> | "However, opening hours were halved, so the fall may reflect closed doors rather than lost interest." |

## Evaluation phrase bank

### Questioning evidence

- "This statistic proves less than it seems because..."
- "The writer relies on a single example..."
- "We are not told who carried out this research..."
- "This may be true for one school, but..."

### Weighing arguments

- "The strongest point here is... because..."
- "This is a fair concern, but it is not a reason to..."
- "Both writers agree that...; they differ only on..."
- "A more balanced view would recognise that..."

# 1(b) planning frame

|         |  |             |  |
|---------|--|-------------|--|
| Form    |  | Audience    |  |
| Purpose |  | My position |  |

## Map the text(s)

| Argument / idea | Text | Agree / disagree / yes, but... | Evaluation: reliable? biased? missing? |
|-----------------|------|--------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
|                 |      |                                |                                        |
|                 |      |                                |                                        |
|                 |      |                                |                                        |
|                 |      |                                |                                        |
|                 |      |                                |                                        |
|                 |      |                                |                                        |

## Paragraph plan

|                             |  |
|-----------------------------|--|
| Opening / hook              |  |
| Point 1 + evaluation        |  |
| Point 2 + evaluation        |  |
| Point 3 + evaluation        |  |
| Conclusion / call to action |  |

## Final check

☐ Correct form conventions  
 ☐ Both bullets addressed  
 ☐ At least two evaluative points  
 ☐ Own words  
 ☐ 250–350 words  
 ☐ Proofread

## Text 1

# Why I Locked the Phones Away

*Blog post by Dr Helen Okafor, head teacher*

- 1 Eighteen months ago, I made the most unpopular decision of my career. Every student's phone now goes into a locked pouch at the school gate and stays there until the final bell. The complaints arrived within hours. Today, I would not reverse it for anything.
- 2 The change in our corridors has been remarkable. At break, students talk to each other again – they play football, argue about music, even (I have seen it with my own eyes) read books. Our librarian reports that more books were borrowed last term than in the previous two years combined. Before the ban, lunchtime looked like a waiting room: rows of silent teenagers, heads bowed over screens.
- 3 The effect on learning has been just as striking. Teachers report that lessons start faster and that students concentrate for longer. Our Year 11 results rose by eight per cent last summer. Research suggests that the mere presence of a phone on a desk reduces attention, even when it is switched off. Why would we allow such a distraction in the one place whose purpose is learning?
- 4 Then there is bullying. Much of the cruelty young people suffer now happens online, and too much of it used to happen during the school day, in our own classrooms. Since the ban, reported incidents of online bullying during school hours have fallen to almost zero.
- 5 Some parents worry about emergencies. I understand, but schools have telephones. In an emergency, parents have always been able to reach their children through the school office, as they did for generations before smartphones existed.
- 6 Childhood is short. I want our students to spend it looking at each other, not at a screen. Every school should have the courage to do the same.

## Text 2 Lock Up the Phones? Teach Us to Use Them Instead

*Newspaper youth column by Amira Haddad, aged 16*

- 1 Every few months, another school announces a phone ban, and the adults applaud. As a student, I understand why. I have seen classmates scrolling under desks and group chats turn nasty. But banning phones treats the symptom, not the problem – and it leaves us less prepared for the world we actually live in.
- 2 Phones are not just distractions. In my school, we use them to check the meaning of words, photograph notes from the board, record our speaking practice and access homework. For students who cannot afford a laptop, a phone is often their only computer. Take it away, and you widen the gap between rich and poor. During the pandemic, schools told us our devices were essential for learning. It seems strange to be told now that they are the enemy.
- 3 A ban also teaches us nothing. In two years, I will be at university or at work, where nobody will lock my phone in a pouch. If school never teaches me how to manage screen time, when will I learn? Self-control is a skill and, like any skill, it needs practice – not removal.
- 4 As for bullying, it does not disappear when the phones do. It simply moves to the bus journey home, to the evening, to the weekend, when no teacher is around to notice. I would rather schools taught us how to report abuse and support each other than pretend the problem stops at the gate.
- 5 And yes, emergencies matter. When a road accident closed our street last year, my mother reached me in seconds. A school office with one telephone and nine hundred students is not the same thing.
- 6 I am not asking for phones everywhere, all the time. Clear rules – phones away in lessons unless the teacher says otherwise – would work. Treat us as people learning to be responsible, not as a problem to be locked away.

## Paper 2 Section A · Task 1: Phones in Schools

**Section A · 40 marks · about 1 hour.** Read both texts in the insert (about 600 words), then answer Question 1(a) and Question 1(b). Suggested timing: read and answer 1(a) 15 min · plan 1(b) 8 min · write 1(b) 35 min · check 2 min.

### Question 1(a) 5 marks

- (i) Explain how the writer of Text 1 tries to persuade readers to support a phone ban. Refer to **two** examples from the text. [3]
- (ii) How convincing is the claim in Text 1 that the ban improved exam results? Give reasons for your answer. [2]

### Question 1(b) 35 marks

Your school is considering banning mobile phones for the whole school day. You have been asked to give a speech to the school council, which is made up of students, teachers and parents. [35]

In your speech you should:

- evaluate the arguments for and against a full ban given in both texts
- give your own view, with reasons, about what the school should do.

Base your speech on what you have read in both texts, but be careful to use your own words. Address both bullet points. Write about **250 to 350 words**. Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 25 marks for the quality of your writing.

**BEFORE YOU WRITE:** Use the planning frame. Circle the form, audience and purpose, and mark each argument in the text: agree, disagree or “yes, but...”.

# Mark scheme · Task 1

## Question 1(a) 5 marks

|          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |   |
|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|
| 1(a)(i)  | Up to 3 marks for identifying techniques with brief explanation of the effect on the reader, e.g.: <i>contrast</i> between the lively corridors now and lunchtime as a silent “waiting room” – makes life before the ban seem joyless; <i>statistic</i> (results up eight per cent) – sounds precise and authoritative; <i>appeal to research</i> – suggests expert support; <i>rhetorical question</i> (“Why would we allow such a distraction...?”) – makes the opposite view seem foolish; <i>personal credibility</i> (“most unpopular decision”, “seen it with my own eyes”) – presents her as honest and brave; <i>emotive ending</i> (“Childhood is short”) and challenge to other schools to show “courage”. 1 mark per technique + 1 for developed explanation, max 3. | 3 |
| 1(a)(ii) | Up to 2 marks for a reasoned evaluation, e.g.: not fully convincing – one year of results, no comparison with other schools or earlier years; the rise could have other causes (a strong year group, new teaching, easier papers); the research is not named. Credit a balanced view: it is supported by teachers’ reports of better concentration.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | 2 |

## Question 1(b) · Reading 10 marks

Mark with the Reading bands on the Marking Guidance page. The top bands need candidates to **evaluate** the ideas in the text, not just repeat them. Indicative content:

**Arguments for a ban (Text 1).** more social break times; more library borrowing; better concentration and faster lesson starts; results up 8%; research on phones reducing attention; online bullying in school hours almost eliminated; emergencies handled by the school office; childhood should be spent face to face.

**Arguments against (Text 2).** phones are learning tools (dictionary, photos of notes, speaking practice, homework); the only computer for poorer students – a ban widens inequality; schools called devices essential during the pandemic; self-control must be practised, not removed; bullying moves outside school where no adult sees; one office phone for 900 students is inadequate in emergencies; suggests clear rules instead of a ban.

**Evaluation opportunities (credit highly).** 8% rise may have other causes; research unnamed; bullying may simply be hidden rather than reduced (Text 2 directly challenges Text 1); anecdotal evidence in both (“seen it with my own eyes”, the road accident); Text 2 does not answer the evidence about attention; both writers want responsible behaviour and differ on the method; Text 2’s compromise answers several of Text 1’s concerns.

## Question 1(b) · Writing 25 marks

Mark with the Writing bands. Check the conventions of a speech (see the Form Toolkit), register suited to the audience, a clear structure, and accurate, varied sentences and vocabulary.

# Model speech • Task 1

A top-band response (323 words). Use it after students have tried the task themselves. It shows one strong answer, not the only one.

Good afternoon, members of the council.

Picture two lunchtimes. In the first, a hall full of teenagers sits in silence, heads bowed over screens. In the second, the same hall is loud with football, arguments and laughter. Most of us would choose the second – and that is exactly the picture Dr Okafor paints in defence of her school’s total phone ban. But before we copy her, we should ask whether a complete ban is really the only way to get there.

Dr Okafor’s strongest point is concentration. It is easy to believe that a phone buzzing on a desk pulls attention away from learning, and her teachers say lessons now start faster. Yet her proudest statistic – an eight per cent rise in results – proves less than it seems. One year of results, with no comparison, could reflect a strong year group or better teaching. We should be impressed, but not persuaded.

Her claim about bullying is weaker still. Online cruelty may have vanished from her corridors, but, as Amira Haddad points out, it simply moves to the bus home and the weekend, where no adult is watching. A ban makes the problem invisible; it does not make it disappear.

Amira also reminds us of something the head teacher ignores: for many students, a phone is their only computer. Removing it entirely would punish those who can least afford a laptop.

So what should we do? I propose a middle path. Phones should be switched off and out of sight in lessons unless a teacher asks us to use them, and kept away in the lunch hall so that break times belong to conversation again. Alongside this, every year group should be taught how to manage screen time and report online abuse.

This is not a weaker rule. It is a smarter one. Let us not lock our problems away – let us teach our students to solve them.

Thank you.

## Why this scores highly

- Opens with a vivid contrast that hooks the audience and fits a spoken form.
- Evaluates, not just repeats: questions the 8% statistic and the bullying evidence.
- Uses Text 2 to challenge Text 1 directly, showing the texts in conversation.
- Clear, reasoned position with a practical proposal drawn from both texts.
- Speech features: direct address, inclusive “we”, a memorable closing line.

Text

## Paying for Paradise

*Magazine feature by a travel writer*

- 1 When I first visited Wadi Sahra twenty years ago, I shared the waterfall with a family of goats and one elderly farmer, who offered me dates and refused to take any money. Last spring I went back. The car park was full by eight in the morning. Plastic bottles floated in the lower pools, music thudded from portable speakers, and a queue of visitors waited to be photographed on the rock where I had once sat alone.
- 2 Wadi Sahra is not unusual. Around the world, beautiful places are being loved to death. Social media has turned hidden valleys, beaches and viewpoints into must-see destinations almost overnight. Local authorities, often short of money, struggle to pay for the rangers and rubbish collection that such crowds require. The numbers are staggering: one popular mountain lake in Europe reportedly received more visitors in a single summer than in the previous ten years combined.
- 3 One solution is gaining ground: charge people to enter. Supporters argue that an entrance fee does two jobs at once. It reduces numbers, because casual visitors think twice, and it raises money that can be spent on rangers, toilets, paths and rubbish collection. Some national parks already charge foreign tourists a fee many times higher than the one paid by local residents, and use the income to protect wildlife. ‘People value what they pay for,’ one park manager told me. ‘When it’s free, they treat it like a rubbish bin.’
- 4 The approach has worked elsewhere. At one famous island beach, a small daily fee and a strict limit on visitor numbers transformed a bay that had been closed because of damage. Within three years, the coral and fish had begun to return, and local people were employed as wardens.
- 5 It is a persuasive argument and, standing among the plastic bottles, I confess I was tempted by it. But the more I thought about it, the more uneasy I became.
- 6 Who, after all, would be kept out? Not the wealthy tourists arriving in air-conditioned four-wheel drives; for them, a fee of fifty or even a hundred dirhams is nothing. It would be families on low incomes, students and the farmer’s grandchildren – people who have walked in these valleys for generations and who would now have to pay to visit their own heritage. A beautiful place should not become a luxury.
- 7 There is also no guarantee that the money would be spent where it is needed. Fees collected by distant authorities have a habit of disappearing into general budgets. And if a fee simply turns a wild place into a ticketed attraction, with turnstiles and a gift shop, something important has already been lost.

- 8 There are alternatives. Visitor numbers can be limited through free online booking, as some popular trails already do. Better public transport would reduce the cars that clog narrow valley roads. Volunteer clean-up days, clear signs and heavy fines for litter would tackle the behaviour that does the real damage. And schools could teach children that a wild place is a gift, not a backdrop for a photograph. None of this requires a turnstile.
- 9 On my last evening, I walked up to the old farmer's house. His son lives there now. He told me that he still refuses to charge visitors anything. 'The water belongs to everyone,' he said. 'But I wish they would take their rubbish home.'
- 10 Perhaps that is the answer: not a fee, but a change in how we behave.

## Paper 2 Section A · Task 2: Paying for Paradise

**Section A · 40 marks · about 1 hour.** Read the text in the insert (about 570 words), then answer Question 1(a) and Question 1(b). Suggested timing: read and answer 1(a) 15 min · plan 1(b) 8 min · write 1(b) 35 min · check 2 min.

### Question 1(a) 5 marks

- (i) Explain how the writer uses her own experiences to influence readers. Refer to **two** examples from the text. [3]
- (ii) How convincing is the writer's argument that an entrance fee would keep out the wrong people? Give reasons for your answer. [2]

### Question 1(b) 35 marks

Your local council is proposing to charge an entrance fee of 50 dirhams per person to visit Wadi Sahra, a popular natural beauty spot near your home. Write a letter to the head of the council giving your views. [35]

In your letter you should:

- evaluate the arguments for and against entrance fees presented in the text
- give your own view, with reasons, about how the beauty spot should be protected.

Base your letter on what you have read in the text, but be careful to use your own words.

Address both bullet points. Write about **250 to 350 words**. Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 25 marks for the quality of your writing.

**BEFORE YOU WRITE:** Use the planning frame. Circle the form, audience and purpose, and mark each argument in the text: agree, disagree or "yes, but...".

# Mark scheme · Task 2

## Question 1(a) 5 marks

|          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |   |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|
| 1(a)(i)  | Up to 3 marks, e.g.: the <i>contrast</i> between her first peaceful visit (goats, a generous farmer) and the crowded, polluted present makes the damage shocking and personal; <i>sensory detail</i> (bottles floating, music thudding, a queue for photographs) lets readers picture the problem; admitting she was “tempted” (“I confess”) makes her seem honest and fair, so readers trust her conclusion; the farmer’s <i>anecdote</i> frames the article and gives her final view a wise, local voice. | 3 |
| 1(a)(ii) | Up to 2 marks for a reasoned judgement, e.g.: partly convincing – it is plausible that a flat fee affects low-income families more than wealthy tourists; but she offers no evidence, and her own article mentions parks that charge local residents less, which could solve the problem she describes.                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 2 |

## Question 1(b) · Reading 10 marks

Mark with the Reading bands on the Marking Guidance page. The top bands need candidates to **evaluate** the ideas in the text, not just repeat them. Indicative content:

**Arguments for fees.** the site is overcrowded and polluted; fees reduce numbers; income pays for rangers, toilets, paths, rubbish collection; other parks charge tourists more than locals and fund wildlife protection; an island beach recovered within three years under a fee and visitor limit, creating local jobs; “people value what they pay for”.

**Arguments against fees.** wealthy visitors are not deterred; low-income families, students and local people are excluded from their own heritage; money may disappear into general budgets; turnstiles and gift shops spoil the wildness.

**Alternatives in the text.** free online booking; better public transport; clean-up days, signs and heavy litter fines; education in schools; changing behaviour.

**Evaluation opportunities (credit highly).** vague statistic (“reportedly”); a single park manager’s quote; the writer’s nostalgic bias; her own evidence of lower local prices weakens her fairness argument; no evidence that fees would be misspent; the island-beach example is strong evidence for fees that the writer does not answer; alternatives also cost money to run; the farmer’s view is one person’s.

## Question 1(b) · Writing 25 marks

Mark with the Writing bands. Check the conventions of a letter (see the Form Toolkit), register suited to the audience, a clear structure, and accurate, varied sentences and vocabulary.

## Model letter • Task 2

A top-band response (303 words). Use it after students have tried the task themselves. It shows one strong answer, not the only one.

Dear Councillor Al Mansoori,

I am writing in response to the council's proposal to charge a 50-dirham entrance fee at Wadi Sahra. I support the idea of a fee, but only if it is designed fairly and its income is spent at the wadi itself.

Anyone who has visited recently will recognise the scene described in a recent magazine feature: full car parks by eight o'clock, plastic bottles in the pools and loud music where there was once silence. Doing nothing is no longer an option. A fee would reduce the crowds and pay for the rangers, bins and toilets the site so clearly lacks.

The writer raises a serious objection: a fee might keep out families on low incomes and local people whose families have walked these valleys for generations. This is a fair concern, but it is not a reason to reject the fee altogether. Her own article mentions parks that charge local residents far less than tourists. Wadi Sahra could do the same, with free entry for nearby villages and reduced prices for students.

Her second worry, that the money might vanish into general budgets, is equally important. I would ask the council to promise publicly that every dirham raised will be spent at the wadi, and to publish an annual account showing how.

Some of her alternatives should be adopted alongside a fee. Free online booking at weekends would spread visitors more evenly, and heavy fines for litter would target the behaviour that does the most harm. However, these measures cost money to run – which is exactly why a fee is needed.

The wadi belongs to all of us, but it will not survive being loved to death. A fair fee, spent wisely, is the best way to protect it for the next generation.

Yours sincerely,  
Sara Rahman

### Why this scores highly

- Clear purpose and position in the opening paragraph – essential for a formal letter.
- Turns the writer's own evidence against her (local discounts) – sharp evaluation.
- Accepts valid objections and adapts the proposal instead of ignoring them.
- Combines ideas from the text into a practical, original solution.
- Formal, respectful register suited to a council leader; strong closing echo of the text.

## Every Student Deserves to Move

*Article by a secondary school PE teacher*

- 1 When people ask me why sport should be compulsory until the final year of school, I tell them about Daniel. At thirteen, Daniel was the boy who ‘forgot’ his kit every week. He was anxious, unfit and convinced he was ‘not sporty’. Three years later, he captained our rowing team. If sport had been optional, he would never have discovered it.
- 2 The health argument alone should settle the debate. Physical inactivity is one of the leading causes of preventable illness worldwide, and habits formed in adolescence tend to last a lifetime. The World Health Organization recommends that young people take part in an average of sixty minutes of physical activity every day. Most do not come close. For many teenagers, school sport is the only exercise they get.
- 3 Sport also builds the qualities employers and universities value most: teamwork, resilience, leadership, and the ability to lose gracefully and try again. You cannot learn those from a textbook. Our school teams have won three regional trophies in the last five years, and those students tell me the friendships they formed are the best part of school.
- 4 Then there is mental health. Exercise reduces stress and improves sleep and mood. At exactly the age when exam pressure is highest, we are considering allowing students to drop the one subject that helps them cope with it. That seems to me not just unwise but irresponsible.
- 5 Some students claim they are ‘not sporty’. In my experience, there is no such thing – only students who have not yet found the right activity, or the right coach.
- 6 Critics say students should be free to choose. But we do not let fifteen-year-olds drop mathematics because they find it difficult. Some things are too important to be optional.
- 7 Sport changed Daniel’s life. Making it optional would mean abandoning the next Daniel on the side of the pitch.

## Why I Dread Wednesday Afternoons

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*Student blog post*

- 1 Every Wednesday at two o'clock, my stomach sinks. It is not the exercise I mind – I walk for an hour most evenings and enjoy it. It is everything else: the changing room, the team captains choosing players in front of everyone, the shouts of 'Come on!' when I miss the ball, the teacher who clearly prefers the students who are already good.
- 2 I am not alone. In a survey of students in my year group that I carried out for a school project, more than half of the girls said they felt self-conscious during PE, and a third said they sometimes pretended to be ill to avoid it. That is not a system that builds lifelong healthy habits. It is one that teaches many of us to hate exercise. Last year, a friend of mine who loves dancing was laughed at during a basketball lesson. She has not played any sport since.
- 3 Supporters of compulsory sport talk about teamwork and resilience. But these can be learned in many ways – in drama, in debating, in music, in volunteering. Why should competitive team games be the only route?
- 4 I am not arguing that schools should give up on physical activity. I am arguing for choice. Let students pick from yoga, dance, swimming, climbing, walking clubs or the gym as well as football and netball. Let them exercise without being ranked against each other. At my cousin's school, older students choose their own activity, and participation has actually gone up.
- 5 Forcing people to do something they hate rarely makes them love it. If we want teenagers to stay active for life, we should help them find something they enjoy – not make them dread Wednesday afternoons.

## Paper 2 Section A · Task 3: Compulsory School Sport

**Section A · 40 marks · about 1 hour.** Read both texts in the insert (about 580 words), then answer Question 1(a) and Question 1(b). Suggested timing: read and answer 1(a) 15 min · plan 1(b) 8 min · write 1(b) 35 min · check 2 min.

### Question 1(a) 5 marks

- (i) Both writers use a personal story. Explain how **each** writer uses a personal story to influence readers. [3]
- (ii) How convincing is the survey evidence in Text 2? Give reasons for your answer. [2]

### Question 1(b) 35 marks

Your school is deciding whether sport should remain compulsory for all students up to Year 11. Write an article for your school magazine. [35]

In your article you should:

- evaluate the views given in both texts
- give your own view, with reasons, on whether sport should be compulsory.

Base your article on what you have read in both texts, but be careful to use your own words. Address both bullet points. Write about **250 to 350 words**. Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 25 marks for the quality of your writing.

**BEFORE YOU WRITE:** Use the planning frame. Circle the form, audience and purpose, and mark each argument in the text: agree, disagree or “yes, but...”.

# Mark scheme · Task 3

## Question 1(a) 5 marks

- |                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |          |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| <b>1(a)(i)</b>  | Up to 3 marks, e.g.: Text 1 uses Daniel's transformation from anxious boy to captain – an emotive success story that makes compulsory sport seem life-changing, and the final line ("the next Daniel") makes opting out seem like abandoning a child; Text 2 opens with her own dread ("my stomach sinks"), making readers sympathise and recognise the experience; she stresses she enjoys walking, so readers see the problem is PE's culture, not laziness. Reward reference to both texts; max 2 if only one text is addressed. | <b>3</b> |
| <b>1(a)(ii)</b> | Up to 2 marks, e.g.: limited – a small, informal survey of one year group, carried out by the writer herself, so it may not be representative or objective; but it gives specific figures and matches the experiences she describes, so it raises a real concern.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <b>2</b> |

## Question 1(b) · Reading 10 marks

Mark with the Reading bands on the Marking Guidance page. The top bands need candidates to **evaluate** the ideas in the text, not just repeat them. Indicative content:

**For compulsory sport (Text 1).** students discover talents they would otherwise miss (Daniel); inactivity causes preventable illness; habits last a lifetime; WHO recommends 60 minutes a day and most teenagers fall short; school may be the only exercise; builds teamwork, resilience, leadership; helps mental health and exam stress; important subjects like maths are not optional; team trophies and friendships.

**Against / for choice (Text 2).** the culture of PE – public team picking, shouting, favouritism – causes dread; survey: over half of girls self-conscious, a third fake illness; compulsion can teach students to hate exercise; teamwork can be learned elsewhere; offer a range of activities without ranking; participation rose at a school offering choice; a friend gave up exercise after being laughed at.

**Evaluation opportunities (credit highly).** both rely on single anecdotes (Daniel, the cousin's school); the survey is small and self-run; the maths comparison can be questioned or turned around; the trophies benefit students who are already sporty; Text 1's claim that every student can find "the right activity" actually supports Text 2's call for choice; Text 1 ignores students who are put off; Text 2 does not explain how to reach students who would choose nothing; the writers agree that activity matters and differ only on form – a compromise is available.

## Question 1(b) · Writing 25 marks

Mark with the Writing bands. Check the conventions of an article (see the Form Toolkit), register suited to the audience, a clear structure, and accurate, varied sentences and vocabulary.

## Model article · Task 3

A top-band response (325 words). Use it after students have tried the task themselves. It shows one strong answer, not the only one.

### Compulsory Sport: Right Goal, Wrong Game?

Ask any student about PE and you will get one of two reactions: a grin or a groan. Our school now has to decide whether the groaners should be allowed to opt out. Two recent pieces of writing – one by a PE teacher, one by a student – suggest the answer is less simple than it looks.

The case for keeping sport compulsory is strong. As the teacher points out, many teenagers get almost no exercise outside school, and the habits we form now may stay with us for life. The story of Daniel, the anxious boy who became captain of the rowing team, is genuinely moving. But one success story cannot tell us how many other students, forced onto the pitch, simply learned to hate it.

That is exactly the student writer's point. Her description of captains choosing players in public will be painfully familiar to many readers. Her survey, suggesting that a third of girls in her year sometimes pretend to be ill to avoid PE, is small and informal, so we should treat it with caution. Even so, it raises a question the teacher never answers: if compulsory sport puts students off exercise, is it really working?

The teacher compares sport to maths, which nobody is allowed to drop. It is a clever comparison, but it cuts both ways. Good maths teachers adapt how they teach to the students in front of them. Why should PE be any different?

In fact, the two writers agree on more than they realise. Both believe physical activity matters. They disagree only about whether students should have a say in what form it takes.

So here is my answer: keep activity compulsory, but make the activity a choice. Offer yoga, dance, swimming and the gym alongside football and netball, and stop ranking students against each other in public. Then Wednesday afternoons might produce more grins – and fewer groans.

### Why this scores highly

- Headline and lively opening suit a school-magazine audience.
- Evaluates evidence on both sides: questions the single anecdote and the small survey.
- Turns the maths comparison around – a sophisticated evaluative move.
- Identifies common ground between the writers before giving a clear view.
- Circular structure (grins and groans) gives a polished, memorable ending.

Text

## Town Divided Over Future of Old Library

*Local newspaper report*

- 1 Plans to transform the 90-year-old Harbour Road Library into a modern 'digital learning hub' have divided residents, with more than 400 people attending a heated public meeting on Tuesday evening. Several residents had to stand outside and listen through the open windows.
- 2 Under the council's proposal, around two-thirds of the library's 40,000 books would be sold or recycled to make space for rows of computers, a video-editing studio, a 3D-printing lab and bookable study pods. The remaining books would be kept in a smaller reading room on the first floor. The work would cost an estimated 2.4 million dirhams and close the building for eighteen months. The plans also include a café and a rooftop terrace, which officials say would bring new visitors into the town centre and help nearby shops.
- 3 Council leader Faisal Karim told the meeting that the library must 'change or die'. 'Visitor numbers have fallen by forty per cent in ten years,' he said. 'Young people aren't coming in, and we can't justify keeping a building open for shelves nobody uses. This is about giving every child in this town the technology and skills they need for tomorrow's jobs.' He added that many families in the area did not have a reliable computer or internet connection at home.
- 4 His words drew applause from some parents and students. Sixteen-year-old Leila Farouk said she had nowhere quiet to study. 'My house is small and noisy. Several of my friends revise in fast-food restaurants because they have nowhere else to go. A study pod with fast Wi-Fi would change everything.'
- 5 But others were furious. Retired teacher Margaret Osei, who has used the library for over fifty years, accused the council of 'vandalism'. 'You cannot download the feeling of browsing a shelf and finding a book you never knew you wanted,' she said. 'And who is this for? The elderly people who come here every morning to read the newspaper and talk to someone? They won't be using a 3D printer.' Her comments were met with loud cheering.
- 6 Local bookseller Tom Reyes questioned the figures. 'Visitor numbers fell because the council cut opening hours in half,' he said. 'Of course fewer people come if the doors are shut.' He also warned that the equipment would be out of date within five years, leaving the town with 'an expensive room full of old computers'.
- 7 Shop owner Rami Aziz also questioned the cost. 'That's 2.4 million dirhams,' he said. 'For that money, you could keep the library open seven days a week for twenty years.'
- 8 A survey published by the council last month found that 62 per cent of respondents supported 'modernising' the library, although critics pointed out that it was carried out

online, meaning that many older residents without internet access were unlikely to have taken part.

- 9 Several speakers suggested a compromise: keeping most of the books while adding a smaller digital area, extending opening hours and running free coding and study clubs for young people. Librarian Anika Das said the library already offered computer classes for older residents, which were 'always full', and that the children's story sessions had a waiting list every week.
- 10 Mr Karim said the council would consider all views before a final vote next month. 'Nobody wants to lose the library,' he said. 'The question is what a library should be in the twenty-first century.'

## Paper 2 Section A • Task 4: The Future of the Library

**Section A • 40 marks • about 1 hour.** Read the text in the insert (about 550 words), then answer Question 1(a) and Question 1(b). Suggested timing: read and answer 1(a) 15 min • plan 1(b) 8 min • write 1(b) 35 min • check 2 min.

### Question 1(a) 5 marks

- (i) Explain how the council leader, Faisal Karim, tries to persuade people to support the plan. [3]  
Refer to **two** examples from the text.
- (ii) How reliable is the council's evidence that the library needs to change? Refer to **two** pieces [2]  
of evidence.

### Question 1(b) 35 marks

You are a member of your town's youth council. The council's community committee has [35]  
asked you to write a report on the proposal to turn Harbour Road Library into a digital  
learning hub.

In your report you should:

- evaluate the arguments for and against the proposal given in the text
- recommend, with reasons, what should happen to the library.

Base your report on what you have read in the text, but be careful to use your own words.

Address both bullet points. Write about **250 to 350 words**. Up to 10 marks are available for  
the content of your answer and up to 25 marks for the quality of your writing.

**BEFORE YOU WRITE:** Use the planning frame. Circle the form, audience and purpose, and mark each argument  
in the text: agree, disagree or "yes, but..."

# Mark scheme • Task 4

## Question 1(a) 5 marks

|          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |   |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|
| 1(a)(i)  | Up to 3 marks, e.g.: dramatic phrase “change or die” – presents the choice as urgent and stark; statistic (a 40% fall in visitors) – sounds factual and hard to argue with; appeals to the future and to children (“every child... tomorrow’s jobs”) – makes opposing the plan seem to harm young people; appeals to fairness – many families lack computers; reassuring close (“Nobody wants to lose the library”) – presents himself as reasonable. | 3 |
| 1(a)(ii) | 1 mark per evaluated piece of evidence, e.g.: the 40% fall may be explained by opening hours being cut in half, so it does not prove people have lost interest; the 62% survey was carried out online, so it probably excluded older residents and is not representative.                                                                                                                                                                             | 2 |

## Question 1(b) • Reading 10 marks

Mark with the Reading bands on the Marking Guidance page. The top bands need candidates to **evaluate** the ideas in the text, not just repeat them. Indicative content:

**For the proposal.** visitor numbers down 40%; young people not using it; skills for future jobs; many families lack computers/internet; students need quiet study space (Leila; friends revising in fast-food restaurants); 62% survey support; a café and terrace could bring visitors and help local shops.

**Against the proposal.** loss of two-thirds of 40,000 books; value of browsing; elderly residents use it for company and newspapers; cost of 2.4 million and 18-month closure; equipment outdated in five years; the money could fund longer opening hours instead; fall in visitors caused by reduced hours; survey excluded older people.

**Compromise ideas in the text.** keep most books with a smaller digital area; extend opening hours; free coding and study clubs; existing computer classes are already popular.

**Evaluation opportunities (credit highly).** reliability of both statistics; emotional language on both sides (“change or die”, “vandalism”); cheering and applause show strength of feeling, not evidence; the decision is hard to reverse once books are gone; the popular computer classes and story sessions show the library can modernise without being rebuilt; Rami Aziz’s “twenty years” claim is unsupported.

## Question 1(b) • Writing 25 marks

Mark with the Writing bands. Check the conventions of a report (see the Form Toolkit), register suited to the audience, a clear structure, and accurate, varied sentences and vocabulary.

## Model report • Task 4

A top-band response (285 words). Use it after students have tried the task themselves. It shows one strong answer, not the only one.

### Report to the Community Committee: The Future of Harbour Road Library

*From: Youth Council representative*

#### Purpose

This report evaluates the council's proposal to convert Harbour Road Library into a digital learning hub and recommends a way forward.

#### The case for change

The proposal responds to real needs. Many local families lack a reliable computer or internet connection, and students such as Leila Farouk have nowhere quiet to study; some of her friends revise in fast-food restaurants. Study pods, fast Wi-Fi and digital training would give these young people a fairer chance.

#### Weaknesses in the evidence

However, the council's evidence is less secure than it appears. The forty per cent fall in visitors must be read alongside the halving of opening hours: fewer people visit a building that is closed. Similarly, the survey showing 62 per cent support was conducted online, so it probably excluded the older residents most affected.

#### The case against

Older residents rely on the library for company as much as for books, and would gain little from a 3D printer. There is also a financial risk: expensive equipment may be outdated within five years. Removing more than 26,000 books could not easily be reversed.

#### Recommendations

1. Keep most of the book collection and reading areas.
2. Convert one floor into a smaller digital zone with study pods and computers.
3. Restore full opening hours, including evenings, so students can study after school.
4. Expand the popular computer classes and add free coding and homework clubs.
5. Carry out a new survey, on paper and online, before the final vote.

#### Conclusion

The choice is not between books and technology. A library that offers both, and is open when people need it, would serve every generation in the town.

### Why this scores highly

- Correct report conventions: title, sender, clear subheadings, numbered recommendations.
- Objective, formal tone – no emotive language, as suits a committee report.
- Dedicated evaluation section questioning the reliability of both statistics.
- Recommendations grow logically from the evaluation and use the compromise ideas.
- Concise conclusion that sums up the judgement in one balanced sentence.

## Marking guidance · Question 1(b)

These bands are written for this pack to support consistent practice marking. They follow the published assessment objectives but are not official Cambridge descriptors. Choose the band that best fits, then the mark within it.

### Reading 10 marks

|      |                                                                                                                                                      |
|------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 9–10 | Thorough, perceptive evaluation of ideas from the text(s); evidence questioned and weighed; ideas developed and combined into a convincing argument. |
| 7–8  | Clear evaluation of several ideas; a range of ideas used and developed with purpose.                                                                 |
| 5–6  | A range of relevant ideas used, some development; evaluation is occasional or simple.                                                                |
| 3–4  | Some relevant ideas, mostly repeated rather than developed; little or no evaluation.                                                                 |
| 1–2  | Limited use of the text(s); may copy or misunderstand.                                                                                               |

### Writing 25 marks

|       |                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 22–25 | Highly effective style and register for the audience; confident command of the form; well-structured, persuasive argument; wide, precise vocabulary; varied sentences; very accurate. |
| 17–21 | Effective style and appropriate register; secure form; clear, logical structure; good vocabulary; mostly accurate.                                                                    |
| 12–16 | Generally appropriate style; some awareness of form and audience; ideas mostly organised; some errors that do not impede meaning.                                                     |
| 7–11  | Simple style; inconsistent register; limited structure; errors sometimes distract.                                                                                                    |
| 1–6   | Little sense of form or audience; weak organisation; frequent errors that impede meaning.                                                                                             |

**QUICK CHECK:** An answer that only repeats the text rarely scores above 6 for Reading, however well it is written. Look for the words “however”, “but”, “this suggests” and “this overlooks”. They usually mark where the evaluation is.

# Score tracker

| Part                       | Max       | Task 1 | Task 2 | Task 3 | Task 4 |
|----------------------------|-----------|--------|--------|--------|--------|
| 1(a) Analysis & evaluation | 5         |        |        |        |        |
| 1(b) Reading               | 10        |        |        |        |        |
| 1(b) Writing               | 25        |        |        |        |        |
| <b>Total</b>               | <b>40</b> |        |        |        |        |

## If your lowest score is...

|                     |                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>1(a)</b>         | Name the technique or claim, quote briefly, then say how it affects the reader or whether it convinces you.                     |
| <b>1(b) Reading</b> | You are probably repeating. Add a “yes, but...” to every idea you use, and question at least two pieces of evidence.            |
| <b>1(b) Writing</b> | Check the form toolkit. Match your register to the audience, plan four or five paragraphs, and save three minutes to proofread. |

## NEXT STEP

# Complete your 0500 preparation

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**IGCSE 0500 Complete Exam Guide (2027):** the method for every question on both papers, with model answers, timing plans and the top 10 mark-losing mistakes.

**IGCSE 0500 Paper 1 Practice Packs 1 & 2 (2027):** six full Paper 1 Reading practice papers with original texts and detailed mark schemes.

**Paper 2 Directed Writing** comes in two volumes: Tasks 1–4 and Tasks 5–8.

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